Sonnet 18

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‘Sonnet 18’

Here is a detailed guide to William Shakespeare’s poem 'Sonnet 18', from the Songs of Ourselves Volume 1 anthology. It includes:

- **Overview**: a line-by-line “translation” of the poem’s meanings and interpretations
- **Writer’s methods**: an exploration of Shakespeare’s poetic choices and potential effects
- **Understanding the text**: an exploration of the themes and ideas within Shakespeare’s poem

Overview

In order to answer an essay question on any poem, it is important to understand what it is about. This section includes:

- An overview of the poem
- A “translation” of the poem, section-by-section
- A commentary of each of these sections, outlining William Shakespeare’s intention and message

‘Sonnet 18’ overview

William Shakespeare’s ‘Sonnet 18’ argues for the power of love, and art such as poetry, to transcend the limits of time. The speaker raises a question about a loved one’s appearance, and concludes that true love lasts despite the passing of time or the fading of looks.

‘Sonnet 18’ breakdown

Lines 1–2

> **“Shall I compare thee to a summer’s day**
> **Thou art more lovely and more temperate:”**

Translation

one to a "summer's day", the comparison would be poor, because a "summer's day" is not as "lovely" or pleasant

Shakespeare's intentions

- Shakespeare begins his sonnet in a traditionally romantic style
- The hyperbolic "more lovely and more temperate" resonates with typically sentimental romantic poetry that praises beauty and a calm nature

Lines 3-6

> **"Rough winds do shake the darling buds of May,**
> **And summer's lease hath all too short a date:**
> **Sometime too hot the eye of heaven shines**
> **And often is his gold complexion dimmed;"**

Translation

- The speaker describes a "summer's day" as less than ideal, explaining why their loved one is "more temperate":
  - In "May", heavy "winds" shake all the budding flowers from the trees
  - Summer is too short
  - Sometimes the sun ("eye of heaven") is "too hot" and, at other times, the sun's "gold" face is not bright, perhaps "dimmed" by cloud

Shakespeare's intentions

- Shakespeare's speaker acknowledges that the usual romantic descriptions are lacking and mostly invalid, which challenges sentimental notions of love:
  - For this speaker, his beloved is the height of beauty, rather than a summer's day

Lines 7-8

> **"And every fair from fair sometime declines,**
> **By chance, or nature's changing course, untrimmed;"**

Translation

- The speaker adds that everything that is "fair" or attractive loses its beauty
- Sometimes one's appearance "declines" by bad luck, or simply the inevitable passing of time

Shakespeare's intentions

- Shakespeare's sonnet attempts an accurate portrayal of beauty: all beautiful things, he suggests, are naturally temporary

> **"But thy eternal summer shall not fade,**
> **Nor lose possession of that fair thou ow'st;**
> **Nor shall death brag thou wander'st in his shade,**
> **When in eternal lines to time thou grow'st:"**

Translation

- The speaker then says that their loved one is different:
  - Their "summer", their pleasant nature, is "eternal"
  - They will never lose the "fair" (attractiveness) they own
  - They will never get weak or unattractive over time ("death" will not "brag" at them becoming frail and wrinkled with "eternal lines")

Shakespeare's intentions

- Shakespeare uses the metaphor of an "eternal summer" to describe their loved one as forever young and attractive in their eyes
- The poem advocates for a love that does not alter over time, or when beauty fades:
  - Shakespeare might also be suggesting that this poem will also live on

Lines 13-14

> **"So long as men can breathe, or eyes can see**
> **So long lives this, and this gives life to thee."**

Translation

- The speaker concludes that as long as human beings "breathe" and can "see", their argument remains true, like their love
- The poem, the speaker says, makes this true forever, and "gives life", or immortalises, the listener

Shakespeare's intentions

- Shakespeare's sonnet ends on a rhyming couplet that sums up the ideas in the poem: the truth held within the poem, like the speaker's love, will last forever

Examiner Tips and Tricks

The mark scheme for CIE Literature for English Paper 1 asks for an understanding of characters, relationships, situations and themes and, specifically, the "deeper meanings of the poem". Examiners advise you to spend more time thinking about, for example, the reason a poet raises certain themes. Sometimes, a poet raises themes and concerns about their

Writer's methods

Although this section is organised into form, structure, and language, it is worth remembering that all of these are considered "writer's methods" in the CIE Literature for English poetry mark scheme. With this in mind, consider the poet's choice of form (the way the poem looks or the type of poem it is), its structure (especially how it ends: is it cyclical or resolved?) and, of course, the language used to create effect and, thus, meaning.

By **focusing** on the **poet's overarching ideas** rather than identifying poetic techniques or translating quotes, you will gain far more marks. That is why all the analysis below is arranged by theme and includes William Shakespeare's intentions in terms of his choices of:

- Form
- Structure
- Language

Form

Shakespeare's 'Sonnet 18' uses the traditional form of a 14–line sonnet to speak directly to a loved one. However, the poem offers an alternative perspective to romance as it takes the form of an argument.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Romantic love	Typically for a sonnet, a turning point comes after the first eight lines, but Shakespeare alters the form of a Petrarchan sonnet to add an additional volta after line twelve to introduce a final summation about the everlasting nature of true love	Shakespeare's sonnets often use a final rhyming couplet to present a conclusive and emphatic wisdom, which deviates from classically sentimental sonnets

Structure

Shakespeare uses the disciplined structure of a sonnet to present a controlled speaker, one whose love is pure and eternal, not a temporary passion.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Romantic love	The poem's iambic pentameter and regular, alternating rhyme scheme is typical for a sonnet, lending itself to	Shakespeare uses a steady rhythm and sophisticated metre to emphasise the steadfast and

Language

Shakespeare describes love in terms of a season, "summer", to introduce the transient nature of beauty and, thus, love should not be based on superficial appearance.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Romantic love	The poem's speaker uses natural imagery to expose the unpredictability of nature (there are "rough winds", summer is short, and the sun can be "too hot"), as well as to symbolise the physical changes that occur over time, but then goes on to describe the "eternal summer" of their loved one	Shakespeare's 'Sonnet 18' suggests that superficial love is like "summer", less than ideal and temporary, but asserts that true love is found in an individual's pleasant nature, which will never "fade"

Understanding the text

All the questions in the CIE Literature for English exam encourage an informed, personal response, which means that you should develop a **sound understanding** of the **poem's themes, main ideas, settings, situations and events**. This will help you to **explore** the **writer's intentions and methods**. This section has been divided into the main theme that William Shakespeare explores in his poem 'Sonnet 18':

- Romantic love

Examiner Tips and Tricks

Writing an introduction can be tricky. Examiners are clear about what they are looking for, though. They reward essays that introduce a "personal and evaluative engagement". To do this, spend time thinking about the question before writing your answer. Ask yourself how the poet raises themes, and why they want their readers to consider these ideas. Often, the poet's aims are connected to the society in which they live, or their personal background. Examiners ask that you use contextual information like this, as support for a personal interpretation.

- William Shakespeare wrote a collection of sonnets in the late sixteenth century:
  - The sonnets often use natural imagery and the weather to show the impermanence of life, or to compare to the constancy of nature
- In 'Sonnet 18' Shakespeare's "summer's day" is presented as a weak comparison for their lover as it is unpredictable and short:
  - The poet later concludes that an "eternal summer" can be found in one's personality or "temperament"
- 'Sonnet 18' alludes to humanist ideas rather than traditional notions of fated love:
  - Instead of being obsessive and in turmoil about love, individuals should practise self-control and assert their free will
  - It concludes "So long as men can breathe or eyes can see/So long lives this", which immortalises the poet's words, and their love
- Shakespearean sonnets are slightly different to the sonnets written by Italian poet Petrarch in the early part of the sixteenth century:
  - These early sonnets were written by aristocrats and tended to be about forbidden and lustful affairs, or beautiful and unavailable women
- Shakespeare's sonnets subvert traditional overly sentimental poetry and offer alternative perspectives on romantic love:
  - In this sonnet, he advocates for love that does not alter over time

For further advice and guidance on how to answer the poetry question, please see our detailed guides on Paper 1 Section A: what the question is asking and how to get full marks. You will also find an example of a full, annotated model answer.

It is important to remember that no marks are given for comments on any of the other poems studied in the anthology. Your response should concentrate only on the poem given.

Sources

https://www.cambridgeinternational.org/Images/414779-2020-specimen-mark-scheme-1.pdf.
Songs of Ourselves: Volume 1: Cambridge Assessment International Education Anthology of Poetry in English. Cambridge University Press & Assessment, 2018.

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